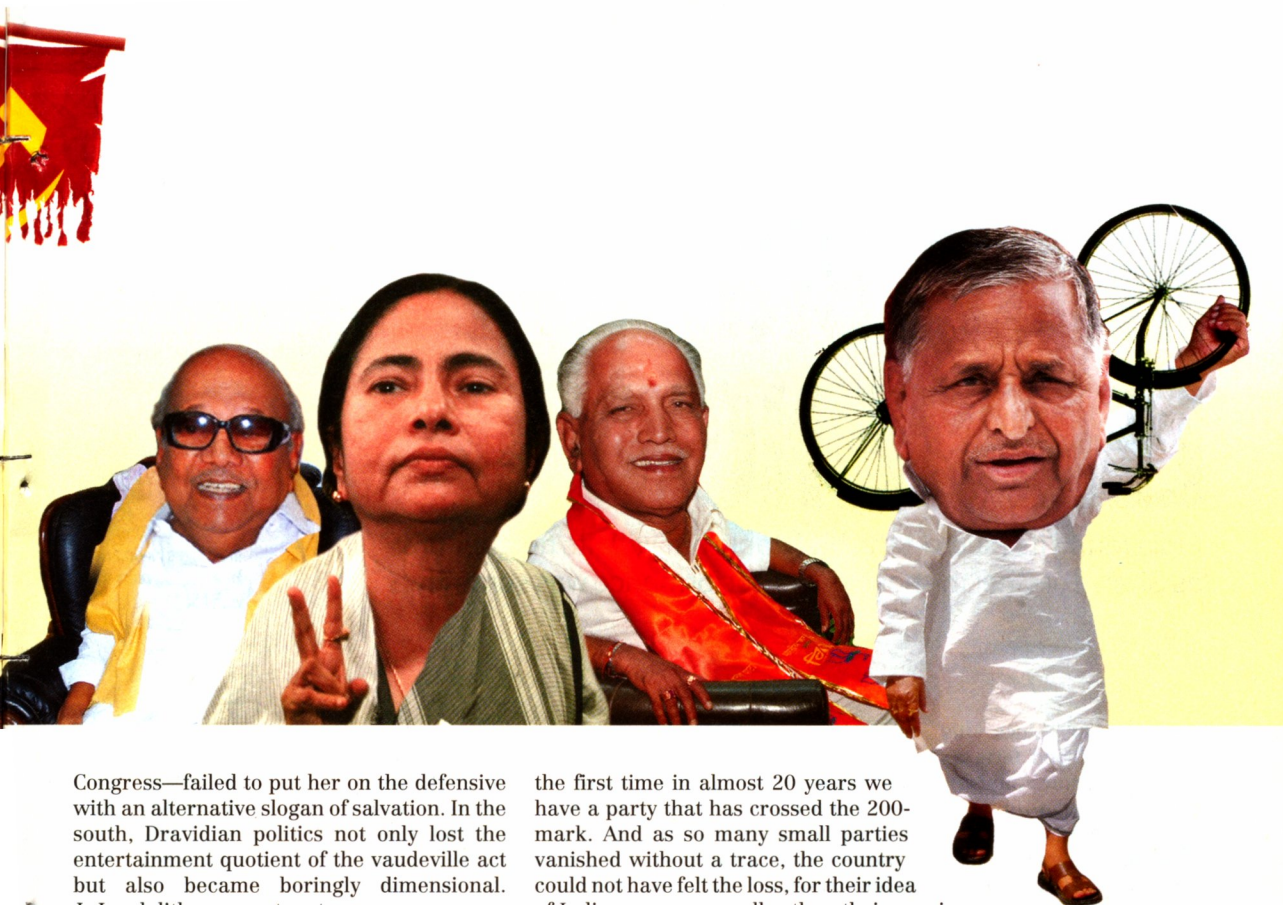




Congress—failed to put her on the defensive with an alternative slogan of salvation. In the south, Dravidian politics not only lost the entertainment quotient of the vaudeville act but also became boringly dimensional. J. Jayalalithaa was at rest.

Still, one story of fossilisation was redeeming in the Opposition's *annus horribilis*. In the twin citadels of the CPI(M), the badly bruised comrades were desperately trying to remain alive. In West Bengal, the man who was once upon a time everybody's favourite McMarxist, ceased to be the Bangla edition of Deng. His modernisation agenda further consolidated the power of the new liberator of Bengal's shirtless. Mamata Banerjee singularly downsized Marx in one of his last, shaky outposts. And in Kerala, the joke was getting unbearable: the war between the party, headed by the Lord Voldemort of Kerala communism, and its chief minister, a Dumbledore whose authority doesn't extend beyond the four porous walls of his office. Fortunately, the winner in this combat between the reformer with a Stalinist mind and the Stalinist with a human touch would be Kerala itself. And the year also saw the commissar of the AKG Bhavan withdrawing himself to his natural habitat: the book. India was relieved.

What gave India some hope amidst such a narrative with an overwhelming motif of rigor mortis was the revival of a national party: for

the first time in almost 20 years we have a party that has crossed the 200-mark. And as so many small parties vanished without a trace, the country could not have felt the loss, for their idea of India was even smaller than their provincial size. The revival, in the end, brought to the national fore the story of two families. The rising Congress made the First Family of Indian politics the most influential extra-constitutional power centre in a democracy. The year of the Congress was also the year of Dynasty rearmed. In 2009, the oldest political party of the subcontinent did not deviate from the script of submission and servitude; it dedicated its victory to the mother, Our Lady of Deliverance, and the son, the Future. The other family, the House of Saffron, failed to provide the counterpoint. The intervention of Mohanrao Bhagwat, the new head of the Sangh Parivar, and the appointment of Nitin Gadkari as the new BJP president may have restored some confidence in the opposition party, but the Indian Right has to update its parivar principles to remain relevant in the 21st century India.

Perhaps that is what Indian democracy needs in the new year: a new set of family values to revive the bipolarity in politics. ■

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